and/or are not under the influence of, or dependent upon, Islamabad, should be India's natural allies. India should adopt an 'anti-engagement' approach, or even a 'containment' policy, vis-à-vis pro-Pakistan factions. If India's natural partners hold power in Kabul, then brilliant, but if not, then India should do whatever it can to help them become powerful. One way to empower India's anti-Pakistan Afghan friends is to buttress their material capacities and mobilise international support in their favour. However, the other way to empower them is also by making pro-Pakistan factions relatively weak, or by actively containing their rise, using (covertly or otherwise) military means if required.

Partisans and conciliators cut across the bureaucratic, diplomatic, and political spectrum of India. Pakistan and its role in Afghanistan, then, form the spirit of the debate between these two foreign policy advocacies. However, instead of being a binary, the conciliators versus partisans debate occurs on a spectrum of ideas and has tremendous nuance on different themes related to Afghanistan. There are, nonetheless, operational indicators (as detailed throughout the book) that highlight the existence of these advocacies. Constantly vying for influence, the conciliators and the partisans have shaped policy outcome at different points in history. The conciliators, for instance, were able to implement an accommodative approach vis-à-vis the Mujahideen government in Kabul in the early 1990s, while they lost out to the partisans in 1996 when the Taliban rose to power. As global attitudes towards radical Islam hardened by the end of the twentieth century and witnessed an emotional explosion after 9/11, the partisans got support internationally and dominated India's diplomatic and security landscape.

The painful realisation that India's vision of terrorism in general and Afghanistan in particular was very different from that of the US, slowly paved the way for the rise of conciliators within India's power corridors. Not surprisingly, by 2015, India warily came to respect (or, one can say, toed the line on) Kabul's decision to reconcile its bilateral differences with Pakistan peacefully, for however long the process lasted. Lastly, far from being mutually exclusive, the approaches advocated by both the conciliators and the partisans have often also worked in tandem. Simultaneous activism of these seemingly disparate advocacies generates dynamics that imparts nuance (but also confusion) to the way India behaves in